

'The most horrible crime ever committed in the whole history of the world': How? Why?

SHORTLY BEFORE THE war, persecution of the Jews had increased (see page 109). The war turned persecution into mass murder and genocide. Six million Jews and many other people who the Nazis wanted to get rid of were murdered. These events are usually known as the Holocaust, although the Jews themselves use the word Churban ('Sacrifice').

When Germany invaded Poland in 1939 another three million Jews came under Nazi control. The war made it impossible to remove the Jews by emigration, so a huge Jewish reservation was planned in Poland. This idea was soon dropped and instead Jews were herded into ghettos in towns in eastern Poland. They were transported there from Germany. Walls were built to keep them in. The Germans allowed them only starvation rations and thousands died from hunger, the intense cold or the disease typhus. The largest ghetto was in Warsaw where 500,000 Jews died.



SOURCE 1 Hungry children in the Warsaw ghetto

From murder to genocide

The treatment of the Jews got worse with the invasion of Russia in June 1941. Special groups of SS soldiers – Einsatzgruppen – were sent to murder all the Jews they could lay their hands on. This was the first mass execution of the war. By the end of 1941 some 500,000 Jews had been shot.

By now Nazi leaders had decided on a 'final solution' to their Jewish problem – to exterminate all of them. So that they could not escape, Jews were forced always to wear a yellow star saying Jew on it, and they were banned from using public transport. In January 1942 leading Nazis met at Wannsee in Berlin to work out the details of the Holocaust. Death camps were built in Poland far away from Germany where Jews were to be worked to death or gassed. Work on building gas chambers and crematoria at camps was accelerated.

A massive operation got under way to move Jews from all over German-occupied Europe to the death camps.

1. Why were the camps built far away from Germany?



SOURCE 2 Map showing concentration and death camps and major 'euthanasia' centres

'THE MOST HORRIBLE CRIME EVER COMMITTED IN THE WHOLE HISTORY OF THE WORLD': HOW? WHY?

SOURCE 3 Kurt Gerstein was a young SS officer who opposed the Nazi regime and secretly tried to pass on information, and sabotage the extermination programme. He witnessed the gassing at Belzec death camp in August 1942 and wrote this account in May 1945, shortly before committing suicide. He describes an early gassing using diesel gases which were later replaced by 'Zyklon B' (hydrogen cyanide)

"The train arrives: 200 Ukrainians fling open the doors and chase people out of the wagons with their leather whips. Instructions come from a large loudspeaker: 'Undress completely, including artificial limbs, spectacles etc. Give your valuables up at the counter. Tie your shoes together carefully.' Then the women and girls have to go to the hairdressers who, with two or three snips of the scissors, cut off all their hair and put it in potato sacks."

Then the procession starts to move – all naked, men, women and children, cripples. Mothers with their babies at their breast, come up, hesitate, enter the death chambers. A tough SS man tells the poor people: 'Nothing is going to happen to you. Just breathe in deeply in the chambers. It will strengthen your lungs. This is necessary because of all the sickness ...' But the majority understand what is happening, the smell reveals their fate to them ... They climb the staircase, hesitate, but they enter the death chambers, driven on by the others behind them or by the leather whips of the SS ... People are treading on each other's toes. Seven to eight hundred in an area of twenty-five square metres. The SS push them in as far as possible. The doors shut, the others are waiting outside in the open, naked ... The people are going to be killed by diesel exhaust gases. But the diesel engine won't start! ... The people wait in their gas chambers. One can hear them crying, sobbing ... After two hours forty-nine minutes the engine starts ... one can see through the little peepholes. After thirty-two minutes they are all dead."

The dead stand like basalt [rock] pillars pressed together in the chambers. There is no room to fall or even to lean over. Even in death one can tell which are the families. They are holding hands in death and it is difficult to tear them apart in order to empty the chambers for the next batch. The corpses are thrown out wet with sweat and urine, smeared with excrement. The corpses of children fly through the air ... dentists tear out the gold teeth and crowns with pincers and hammers ... Some of the workers check the genitals and anus for gold, diamonds and valuables."

The naked corpses are carried on wooden stretchers only a few metres to the ditches which are 100 × 20 × 12 metres in size. After a few days, the corpses swell up and then collapse so that one can throw another layer on top of this one. Then ten centimetres of sand are strewn on the top so that only the occasional heads or arms stick out."

Some children and adults were used for hideous medical experiments. For example, in 1945 a doctor called Heissmeyer injected virulent tuberculosis organisms into twenty French and Russian Jewish children aged between five and twelve years; they became seriously ill, were injected with morphia and then, in the words of an assistant, they were 'hung like pictures around the walls until they died'.

SOURCE 4 Captain Robert Daniel, a tank commander, discovered Belsen concentration camp in April 1945. On smashing through the gates in his tank he found the following horrors – which he recalled in 1995

"A trench 150 yards long, and filled with naked bodies. Parts of the corpses kept moving. You would see an arm rise, then a leg, sometimes whole bodies would come to the surface. This was the natural gases and acids from the bodies at work ..."

The camp hospital, a hangar full of bunk beds eight tiers high. Every bed was occupied, but 90 per cent of the patients were dead, many of them drowned in excreta from the beds above. All had been too weak to move. The sight and the smell were completely appalling, they were all completely naked ..."

In the third hangar ... the swollen, naked body of a woman, five or six days dead, and sitting on it, playing at drawing lots with straw, were a group of young children ... At the perimeter fence ... a group of prisoners who had attempted to escape were caught on the wire. Six Hitler Youths were amusing themselves by shooting them, not to kill but to cause most pain. They were shooting the men in the balls and the women in the crotch. It was an unspeakable sight. I shot four of the Hitler Youth and the other two ran away ... There were worn paths to each of the gas chambers and on the side, a pile of spectacles at least six feet high ... There were at least 3000 inmates still just alive. They were all starving, and skeletons to look at. The irony of the whole thing was that outside the wire lay the most fertile part of the German Rhineland, with fields of potatoes and green vegetables of every kind."